

March 5, 2026

Dear Michael Dwight Sparks,

Congratulations on your admission to the [Department of Economics PhD program](#) at UC San Diego for the 2026-2027 academic year. We are honored that you are considering UC San Diego Economics for your graduate education and are excited about the prospect that you are joining our vibrant community of graduate and professional students.

Our departmental climate reflects our commitment to impactful research and collaboration. Students like you play a central part in what makes [our department](#) world class. We anticipate that you will have choices among a number of top Ph.D. programs. In making your final decision, we urge you to consider the unique strengths of UC San Diego's Department of Economics such as the recent opening of our new Economics building, Brian C. Malk Hall, which offers state of the art facilities, classrooms, and graduate student dedicated spaces—all in close proximity to faculty offices, so the spirit of collegiality extends from faculty and staff to PhD students like you. We also offer a unique pathway for funding your years at UC San Diego via our Point System, which allows students to extend their funding into a 6th year of studies through a variety of qualifying mechanisms.

Our doctoral program is globally recognized for its academic rigor and preparation of bright, burgeoning [economists](#) within academia, government, the private sector and non-profit organizations. Our inclusive and experiential approach supports a cohesive research environment among a diverse group of faculty and graduate students, and incentivizes learning-by-doing in research assistant and teaching assistant roles.

In the coming weeks, you will hear more from us regarding opportunities to learn about the department (including a virtual open house in late March) before you decide whether to accept our offer of admission. At this time also please feel free to directly contact [faculty members](#) in your fields of primary interest. If you have any questions about the program or this offer, please don't hesitate to contact us at [econ-phdadmissions@ucsd.edu](mailto:econ-phdadmissions@ucsd.edu).

Your total intended support is described on the pages that follow. At UC San Diego, the general financial support package includes a minimum commitment of \$37,500 plus tuition and mandatory fees during 2026-27. If you are not a California resident, the non-resident supplemental tuition will also be covered during the 2026-27 academic year. This total one-year package is worth at least \$58,875 (California residents) or \$73,977 (non-California residents) based on the 2025-26 costs.<sup>1</sup> Additional intended funding amounts and durations beyond the committed campus package are contingent on the availability of funds and are not guaranteed. Given the large and growing undergraduate enrollments in our Economics majors, we have been able to offer Teaching Assistant positions to our PhD students through their fifth year and, sometimes, even a sixth year, based on the Department's Point System that provides eligible pathways for extended funding. We expect that our prospective undergraduate enrollments will continue to support similar opportunities to you during your time in our PhD program.

The committed financial support package is contingent upon your meeting the [eligibility requirements](#) throughout your graduate studies. For example, students must maintain full-time registration,

<sup>1</sup> Non-resident supplemental tuition (NRST) is covered for all non-California residents in Year 1 of the program.

satisfactory progress towards the degree, good standing as defined by campus and your graduate program, and enrollment status that is within the supported time limit. Employment-based financial support is also contingent upon maintaining eligibility for employment, such as valid work authorization, completion of relevant training, and compliance with the [disclosure requirement](#) based on California Senate Bill 791. These terms and conditions for financial support are subject to change if required by law or as a result of action by Federal and/or State governments or the Administration of the University of California San Diego and/or UC Regents.

If you are admitted with or later receive an extramural award or contract, this extramural award or contract will be considered your primary source of support. Funds from this primary source of support will be used first to cover tuition and fees and/or provide monthly funding, subject to restrictions of the extramural award/or contract. Any subsequent financial support from University funds will be used only if there is a shortfall in the primary source of support to meet the first-year commitment.

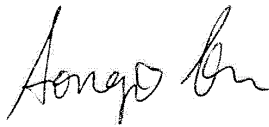
The decision to pursue a graduate degree is a deeply personal and transformative one. We hope this financial support package illustrates our strong support for graduate students here at UC San Diego.

We hope you decide to join our graduate program and Triton community. We look forward to your decision by April 15, 2026. Please reach out to [econ-phdadmissions@ucsd.edu](mailto:econ-phdadmissions@ucsd.edu) with any questions.

Sincerely,



Marc Muendler  
*Department Chair*



Songzi Du  
*Graduate Admissions Chair*

**Total package.** As a reminder, **the committed UC San Diego package is a minimum of \$37,500 in Year 1** in the form of salary and/or stipend plus tuition and mandatory fees. The program-specific financial support package above and beyond this committed package is contingent on availability of funds and may differ from the intended sources of support listed below. Students must be eligible for any financial support; nothing in the table below constitutes an offer of employment. Full details follow this table.

| Year in program | Total intended sum of salary (employment) and stipend (non-employment)       | Intended source of support       |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| 1 (26-27)       | \$37,500 stipend across 9 months<br><a href="#">Tuition and Fee Coverage</a> | Non-Employment Financial Support |
| 1 (26-27)       | \$2,000 stipend                                                              | Summer Research Fellowship       |

We intend to provide support at or above this level for years 2-5 contingent on availability of funds and other specifications. This support may include employment as an Instructional Assistant or Graduate Student Researcher. For a full description of these assignments visit [Graduate Employment](#).

Students who remain in the Ph.D. program beyond the fifth year may be responsible for tuition and fees, and typically support themselves through external doctoral fellowships, Graduate Student Researcher positions, teaching assistantships, or Associate-Instructor teaching assignments, if available. As mentioned previously, the Department of Economics established a Point System that offers limited employment opportunities for students during their 6th year through eligible channels.

### **Employment as a component of the general financial support package**

The Department of Economics expects to offer employment opportunities as part of the funding package during years 2-5, continuing our long tradition of concurrent employment for our PhD students. Employment is required to receive the employment-based component of the funding package and is concurrent with your graduate studies. Employment offers are based on the needs and

funding sources of the University. In the situation where an initial offer is declined, no replacement funding should be expected. During terms in which you are employed as a Graduate Student Researcher ([GSR](#)) or Teaching Assistant or other Academic Student Employee ([ASE](#)), your compensation will be governed by the collective bargaining agreement(s) which cover your employment title.

The Department of Economics intends to offer additional employment opportunities contingent on the availability of funds and the needs of the University. This intention does not constitute an offer of employment. Academic quarters with GSR or ASE appointments totaling at least 25% include tuition and mandatory fees.<sup>1</sup>

| <b>Period</b> | <b>Employment title</b> | <b>Percent effort each quarter</b> | <b>Minimum salary</b>                                             |
|---------------|-------------------------|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Years 2-5     | ASE                     | 50%                                | Based on 26-27 salary rates, currently not available <sup>2</sup> |

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<sup>1</sup> Beginning in Year 2, NRST is not provided for students that are eligible to become a CA resident. Thus, all eligible students are expected to become a CA resident by the beginning of their 2nd year in the program. Your program and the [UC San Diego Residence Deputy](#) can assist you in these policies. Students who are ineligible to establish residency will have NRST coverage in years 1-3 and for 3 years following advancement to candidacy.

<sup>2</sup>Salary rates currently reflect [2025-2026 Student Academic Title Rates](#). Salary rates will be adjusted to 26-27 rates when available.